

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Dr Yasser Iqbal

Address: 63 York Road Cheam SM2 6HN

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: To whom it may concern,

I am writing to express my full support of the planning application DM 2025/01591.

As a local resident living a 4-minute walk from the proposed centre, I am very much in favour of the establishment of a community hub of this kind within the very community that it would serve.

Firstly, there is a significant local Muslim population and currently there is no permanent facility in the area for their needs, thus putting increased pressure on facilities that are further away for broader community activities.

I am impressed that the plans have not only aimed to address this shortfall but also deliver value for the whole local community. The designs include 3 halls - one for prayers, a dedicated and dignified space for women, and a multi-purpose hall for community use and activities.

As a Doctor and NHS Consultant in Emergency Medicine, I recognise the need for inclusive community hubs and the immense benefits they can bring in improving personal wellbeing and health outcomes through health awareness, education and promotion activities, as well as simply opportunities for direct social interaction. This is especially important for both young people and elderly residents. I also value the much-needed social and educational benefits that the community centre would bring to the entire local population through its planned activities - examples listed in the application include fitness classes, elderly support, inter-faith coffee mornings, and health promotion. I am particularly pleased that these social activities are a key

feature that the site intends to deliver.

Being a parent of children that attend and have attended Avenue Primary Academy, and living so close by, I feel that I have good insight and several years direct experience of the traffic situation around the school. From my observations and perspective, I do not expect there to be any adverse impact of significance from this centre at peak school travel times.

This is because the only potential clash that anyone could reasonably cite would be on Friday afternoons where Friday prayers at the centre might coincide with the school pick up time. At all other peak school travel times, I would expect there to be negligible low intensity use of the facility and so no impact observed.

However, I expect no adverse impact on Friday afternoons either. The simple reason being that the current status quo is that BASMA have been holding Friday prayers in staggered sittings only 200m away in St John's Hall for several years now. This has been operated successfully and responsibly without any noticeable difference or disruption to traffic from any other day of the week. A significant number of attendees live in close proximity to the hall and so I can confirm that, like myself and my family members, many already walk to attend Friday prayers there.

Furthermore, the proposal includes the addition of 14 parking spaces, staggered Friday congregational prayer times away from Friday school pick-up time and support for sustainable travel through the installation of cycle racks. I therefore feel this could potentially even have a net positive impact on the current levels of traffic for the area from the status quo. With 2 of the parking spaces being for disabled parking, this will also improve accessibility and safety for some of our residents with mobility issues.

Despite the above, the application also lists other measures to try to mitigate potential traffic issues further still, such as volunteer traffic marshals and parking management initiatives. This shows responsible and thoughtful consideration for neighbours and local residents in the planning process, and awareness of potential local concerns about traffic and road safety around the school during peak travel times with conscientious efforts to address these.

The building designs and appearances look aesthetically pleasing yet still modest without significant expansion of the current footprint of the building. Together with the preservation of green spaces, I feel that they aim to nicely maintain the look and character of the local area.

The site will also retain a publicly accessible defibrillator and there are also plans to host training sessions in Basic Life Support and CPR for the public. All of these would continue the legacy of the old Ambulance station in helping to save lives of local people.

I therefore feel that such a facility has been much-needed for a long time and would be effectively used by and beneficial for all of the local population, rather than just serving the currently unmet needs of the Muslim population alone. Having reviewed the application, I feel BASMA's aims are aligned with this through the various initiatives they have listed. I feel these are well thought out

and will represent a positive contribution to the area and entire community.

For these reasons, I respectfully request the Council to approve the application.

Your sincerely

Dr Yasser Iqbal